

“Can you believe it? Ninety percent off, and free shipping when you order ten!” my couponing peers raved about the Macy’s special on a coupon forum board. I was amazed by the dramatic savings, but it had taken at least three months of indiscriminate spending to make me realize I wasn’t saving anything at all, buying things I didn’t need just because my deal-seeking peers were.

I had to quit cold turkey—at least until I was pregnant with my seventh child and hell-bent on ordering some high-end boutique quality blankets with yet another introductory offer. With a special “\$20 code” offered to new customers, I would get a generous twenty dollars’ worth of merchandise free. I learned to use my husband’s name and e-mail address for an additional order since most of the offers were one per customer, and my husband could be considered a separate customer. With these special introductory offers, I enjoyed free baby clothes and receiving blankets that were delivered right to my door, along with huge discounts on a much-needed (unlike the cashmere sweaters) high chair and car seat.

I didn’t have to rely on my own Internet surfing to discover these special offers, either. It seemed like a new website popped up every day that would do all the legwork for me—alerting consumers to new sales and special discount code offers that were updated frequently throughout the day. While there are still the occasional free sample or introductory special prices offered today, the landscape of freebie offers is nothing like what I experienced during my first two years online. Now, the offers can morph and disappear from one hour to the next, meaning anyone who is intent on